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Gifting a warm-glow effect: how identity influences charitable gifting

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Abstract

Purpose – This work explores how recipients' identity influences givers' choice of charitable gifts, their propensity to deviate from gifting registries and how it impacts social ties.

Design/methodology/approach – We conducted five experiments involving diverse charities to explore the above effect, investigate the mediating role of a warm-glow effect and examine the moderating effect of social closeness and anonymity on gift preferences.

Findings – Givers deviate from the registry in favor of alternatives that are congruent with the recipient's identity due to the givers' desire to gift a warm-glow effect. Socially close givers are more likely to deviate from the gift registry to enhance social ties. Recipients receive a higher warm-glow effect when distant givers give unrequested identity-congruous gifts, thus improving social relationships.

Practical implications – This study will help organizations determine which identities a specific charity should highlight in its campaigns. Marketers can encourage consumers to prefer charitable gifts by emphasizing the relational and warm-glow benefits.

Originality/value – This is the first study to examine the effect of the recipient's identity on givers' preference for charitable gifts. Specifically, while giving charitable gifts, givers are likelier to donate to a charity whose identity is congruent with the recipient.

Keywords Gift-giving, Charitable gifts, Prosocial behavior, Warm-glow effect, Identity-based motivation

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Imagine that your friend invites you to his/her birthday party and shares their gift registry, which consists of a charitable gift (CG). While donating, you encounter another charity that is more congruent with your friend's identity. Will you deviate from the gift registry? In this research, we examine how preference for CGs is influenced by the recipient's identity.

CGs do not directly benefit the recipient since they are donations to a charitable organization that a giver gives on a recipient's behalf (Maciejewsky, 2008). About 47% of recipients showed an inclination toward CGs, which indicates their popularity (Simpson, 2022). Despite this, very little is known about them, factors that influence their preference, and how they impact interpersonal relationships. Academic research has thoroughly studied the gifting phenomenon (Givi et al., 2022) as well as charitable donations (Bekkers and Wiepking, 2011). However, research on charitable gifting is at a nascent stage due to its newness. Since donating to charity on your own versus as a gift for someone is a distinct phenomenon, research



findings of the former may not be applicable to the latter. Therefore, we investigate how givers decide upon CGs to elicit appreciation from recipients.

CGs are expected to provide emotional benefits to the recipients through satisfaction and joy (Maciejewsky, 2008). Certain recipients prefer them as they enable them to indulge in altruistic behavior by contributing to society (Andreoni, 1990) while fostering a moral identity (Aquino and Reed, 2002). However, related research has also shown that recipients do not always appreciate CGs when gift-givers mispredict recipients' preferences (Ok et al., 2020). Due to contradictory findings, the literature is inconclusive regarding CGs' appreciation and factors that impact their efficacy. Therefore, there is a gap in our understanding of the asymmetries between givers' and recipients' preferences for CGs.

Asymmetries in the preference between givers' and recipients' gifting preferences hamper social ties (Chan and Mogilner, 2016), which emphasizes the importance of gift registries. Despite this, givers sometimes prefer freely chosen gifts to convey their intimacy with recipients (Ward and Broniarczyk, 2016), which may displease recipients and adversely impact social relationships (Waldfoegel, 1993). Therefore, extant research has focused on identifying factors that help givers match recipients' preferences. One such factor that related literature emphasizes is the role of identity. While one school of thought posits that recipients appreciate gifts that are congruent to their identity (Gino and Flynn, 2011), whereas another school of thought posits that they prefer gifts that match givers' identity (Paolacci et al., 2015). Such contradictory findings preclude our understanding of how identity impacts preference and/or appreciation of CGs. Therefore, our work attempts to study how recipients' identity influences givers' choice of CGs, their propensity to deviate from CG registries, and how this divergence affects social ties.

Based on identity-based motivation research (Oyserman, 2009), using five studies, we show that gift-givers deviate from a CG registry if they encounter an option that is highly congruous with the recipient's identity to gift them a warm-glow effect. Moreover, close givers possess a higher propensity to do so. Lastly, recipients experience greater warm glow when receiving an identity-congruent gift from distant givers than close givers, resulting in enhanced relationship closeness. This work contributes in several ways. Firstly, it studies CGs—an under-explored practice in gift-giving literature. Secondly, we highlight the influence of identity on charitable gifting preference. Thirdly, we demonstrate the effect of a warm glow in the gift-giving context. Lastly, we also explore how CGs enhance interpersonal cohesiveness. Our findings offer executable tactics to organizations to promote CGs to support the needy.

2. Theory development

2.1 Gift-giving and role of identity

Although gift-giving is largely undertaken to develop and maintain social ties (Chan and Mogilner, 2016), oftentimes, there exists a mismatch between givers' and recipients' preferences, which can be detrimental to relational closeness (Ward and Broniarczyk, 2016). Therefore, extant literature has attempted to explore the reasons behind this mismatch (Givi and Galak, 2017) to minimize the associated disappointment (Waldfoegel, 1993). However, gifting research has not yet conclusively demonstrated how gifts that match a recipient's identity are evaluated. Specifically, some studies (Paolacci et al., 2015) report that gifts that match a giver's characteristics are well-received, while others (Gino and Flynn, 2011) contend that gifts that match a recipient's identity elicit gratitude and improve social ties. Therefore, extant research has generated mixed findings concerning the role of identity in gifting. According to identity-based motivation research (Oyserman, 2009), individuals are likely to prefer identity-congruent products to identity-incongruent ones since they communicate who they are and aspire to be through their consumption choices (Das, 2014). Moreover, individuals not only use identities to make their own decisions but also judge the actions and purchases of others based on their own identities (Pratap et al., 2016).

Gifts play a fundamental role in reinforcing personal and social identities (Klein *et al.*, 2015). A recipient's identity can considerably influence the gifting decisions of the giver. Givers are likelier to choose gifts that align with the recipient's self-identity, such as hobbies or interests, rather than their own preferences to communicate their knowledge about the recipient and strengthen social ties (Gino and Flynn, 2011). Additionally, the relationship between the giver and the recipient was an essential factor in gifting decisions (Bagozzi *et al.*, 1999). For example, givers are more likely to choose gifts that reflect their preferences when giving to close friends or family members but are more likely to select gifts based on the recipient's preferences when giving to acquaintances or colleagues (Ward and Broniarczyk, 2016). These findings suggest that a recipient's identity and the relationship between the two parties can influence gifting choices.

2.2 Charitable gifts and identity

Social psychology research suggests that people are more likely to donate to causes that align with their identity, values, and beliefs (Aquino and Reed, 2002; Chapman *et al.*, 2020). Also, empirical evidence is available to demonstrate how various sources of morality (such as moral emotion, moral judgment, and moral identity) can simultaneously and cooperatively influence prosocial behavior (Septianto and Soegianto, 2017). Matching the donor's identity with the charity's mission and values can increase their connection with the cause, leading to greater donation intentions (Sargeant and Lee, 2004). For example, a study found that people who identified as environmentalists were likelier to donate to an environmental cause when the solicitation message emphasized the compatibility between the cause and their identity (Chapman *et al.*, 2020). Therefore, charities that consider the identity of their donors in their fundraising appeals are likely to be more successful in securing donations.

Charitable gift-giving is a popular form of philanthropy that has recently gained attention (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2015). CGs are donations made by givers on a recipient's behalf to support a cause instead of spending money on a gift that directly benefits a recipient. As they lack tangibility and are not technically for the recipient, factors influencing their appreciation remain unclear due to previous literature's mixed findings. Maciejewsky (2008) suggests that recipients appreciate such gifts as they provide emotional benefits from helping others. Additionally, such gifts can strengthen social connections and enhance the perception of the gift-giver as a caring and socially responsible individual (Aquino and Reed, 2002). These findings highlight the potential benefits of such gifts in enhancing social cohesion and such gifts may effectively promote individual and collective well-being. While others (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2015; Ok *et al.*, 2020) indicate that recipients do not appreciate such gifts, especially when such gifts are unrequested. Therefore, CGs, especially unrequested ones, may be inappropriate for pleasing recipients.

Research on CGs is nascent and has not thoroughly examined the factors leading to their appreciation. Existing literature has examined charitable donations and the significant role of identity in charitable donations (Chapman *et al.*, 2018, 2020). However, these findings may not apply to CGs, as the two constitute separate phenomena. Additionally, the gift-giving domain also indicates the influence of identity on gift preference and highlights that givers prefer to give gifts that match recipients' identity to signal relational closeness (Gino and Flynn, 2011). Consequently, identity may potentially exert a significant influence within the context of charitable gifting. Therefore, we aim to examine the role of identity in charitable gifting.

In this research, we suggest that if an unrequested CG is highly congruent with a recipient's identity, it is likely to be appreciated, according to the findings of identity-based motivation research and our previous discussion. Hence, CGs that match a recipient's identity may diminish the negative impact of receiving an unrequested gift and are more likely to be appreciated. However, since the recipient will not use the gift, one can question the relevance

of an identity-congruent charity in recipients' appreciation of such gifts. Therefore, we discuss the emotional utility one experiences while engaging in prosocial behavior that can be *gifted* to another individual through CGs.

2.3 Warm glow as a mediating variable

People feel good about themselves when they help others, referred to as the *warm-glow* effect (Isen, 1970). The warm glow effect is where individuals experience positive emotions from prosocial behavior. Later, Andreoni (1990) suggested that people experience a psychological benefit called a "warm glow" when they donate to a common good instead of spending on themselves. This effect may be due to the activation of reward centers in the brain that are associated with positive emotions (Moll et al., 2006). This phenomenon has been empirically studied in prosocial and pro-environmental behavior (Hartmann et al., 2017). Hartmann et al. (2017) compare altruistic and warm glow motivations for pro-environmental behavior and conclude that warm glow has a more significant impact than altruistic on driving pro-environmental behavior. Overall, these findings suggest that the warm-glow effect may play an important role in motivating individuals to engage in prosocial behavior and contribute to the well-being of others.

According to Andreoni (1990), this warm glow arises due to individuals' satisfaction from knowing their actions have helped others. Moreover, Bekkers and Wiepking (2011) found that individuals are more likely to donate when they can be publicly acknowledged. Overall, the warm glow effect has important implications for the design of effective fundraising campaigns.

Using identity-based motivation research, we hypothesize that givers are more likely to deviate from the recipient's explicitly requested gift registry when a CG closely resembles the recipient's identity. We predict this propensity to deviate because givers want to gift a warm-glow effect to the recipient. Further, we hypothesize that close (versus distant) givers are more likely to deviate from the requested gift registry when presented with a high identity-congruent CG. Moreover, when presented with high identity-congruent CGs, givers are more likely to deviate from the requested gift registry when the gift is given under a non-anonymous (versus anonymous) condition. That is, givers prefer to deviate only when they receive attribution. Lastly, the giver-recipient relationship strengthens when the deviation from the registry happens in favor of a high (versus low) identity-congruent CG. This is more likely to be evident in the case of socially distant givers. More formally:

- H1a. Givers' likelihood of deviating from the requested CG registry is significantly higher when givers encounter gifts that are congruent (vs. incongruent) with the recipient's identity.
- H1b. The above effect is mediated through a warm-glow effect.
- H2. When encountering a gift that is congruent with the recipient's identity, the likelihood to divert from the requested CG registry is significantly higher among close as compared to distant givers.
- H3. When encountering a gift that is congruent with the recipient's identity, the likelihood of diverting from the requested CG registry is significantly higher among non-anonymous givers than anonymous givers.
- H4. Recipients receiving unrequested identity congruent CGs from socially distant (vs. close) givers feel a higher warm glow effect, which enhances their relationship strength with the giver.

3. Methodology and pretest

To test our hypotheses, we used an experimental design as it has been commonly used in the gift-giving context (Cavanaugh *et al.*, 2015; Givi and Galak, 2017).

3.1 Pretest

A pretest was conducted to establish that gift-givers preferred charitable gifts that are highly congruent with a recipient's identity. The participants ($N = 68$) were randomly assigned to either high-identity congruent or low-identity congruent charitable gift conditions.

They read about their colleague who is passionate about football and trains school children for free in football. Later, they read that they were invited to this colleague's birthday party. In the high identity-congruence condition, they read that while browsing online for a suitable gift, they came across a sports-related charity and decided to donate to it (on behalf of this colleague) as a gift. On the other hand, in the low identity-congruence condition, they donated to a music-related charity. Lastly, participants were asked to rate their purchase intention for the given charity and the extent to which the CG was congruent with the recipient's identity. A one-way ANOVA with purchase intention as a dependent variable showed a main effect of identity such that high-identity congruent CG was significantly higher than its counterpart ($M_{\text{high}} = 4.77$, $M_{\text{low}} = 3.79$; $F(1, 66) = 6.79$, $p < 0.011$; Cohen's $d = 0.63$). Participants in the high identity-congruent gift condition perceived the charitable organization as highly congruent with the recipient's identity ($M_{\text{high congruent}} = 5.09$, $SD_{\text{high congruent}} = 0.62$; $M_{\text{low congruent}} = 3.43$, $SD_{\text{low congruent}} = 0.74$) than the low identity-congruent condition. Therefore, the pretest demonstrated that gift-givers prefer to donate to a charity that closely matches the recipient's identity.

4. Study overview

We demonstrate that gift-givers will deviate from a CG registry if they encounter a more identity-congruous option, and this propensity is mediated by givers' tendency to maximize the warm-glow effect experienced by the recipient (Study 1A and 1B). Compared to distant givers, we predict that close givers are likely to choose a higher identity congruent gift (Study 2). We also predict that givers are not likely to deviate from the registry if they do not receive the attribution for the gift (Study 3). Finally, we show that recipients experience a higher degree of warm glow on receiving identity-congruent gifts (vs. less congruent), strengthening social ties (Study 4).

5. Study 1

5.1 Study 1A

Study 1 intended to test Hypothesis 1a and Hypothesis 1b. We had participants engage in a consequential gift-giving situation that involved giving a CG to an office colleague. We employed a single factor between-subjects design by varying the degree of identity congruence of the CG.

5.1.1 Method. Initially, 123 students at a Southeast Asian university participated in the study. We had a final sample of 105 students (40% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 23.6$ years), as 18 participants were excluded for failing an attention check (common for all studies) that asked a question: "Everyone likes to watch television programs. Recently, sports television programs have seen a major increase in ratings. Many sports start with the letter 'B'. However, we ask that from the list below, you select a sport that does not start with the letter 'B'. Thank you for doing this task. a. Basketball, b. Football, c. Baseball, d. Bowling."

Participants read about their colleague who is passionate about guitar and gives free guitar lessons to school children. Later, they read that they were invited to their colleague's birthday party, and the colleague requested them to donate to a specific charity (Option A-Charity for learning art and culture). In the high identity-congruence condition, the participants read that

while browsing online for the same charity, they encountered another charity (Option B- Charity for learning musical instruments, especially guitar). In the low identity-congruence condition, participants read the same scenario. The only difference was that while browsing for the given charity, they encountered another charity (Option B- Charity for learning singing, especially classical singing). The participants rated their relative preference between the two gifts on a 7-point scale (1 = Option A, 7 = Option B).

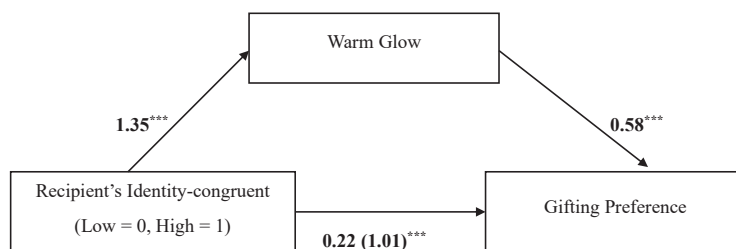
Furthermore, they completed a three-item manipulation check adapted from Paolacci *et al.* (2015) assessing the gift's identity congruence with the recipient (e.g. "The gift reflects recipient's interests,"; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.74$). We also tested for the warm-glow effect using four items on a 7-point scale adapted from Hartmann *et al.* (2017) (e.g. "With the receipt of this gift, the recipient will have a pleasant feeling of personal satisfaction by doing something about the cause"; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.86$). After responding to the primary dependent variable of the study, participants were always asked to complete an attention check. (Appendix and Data available at https://osf.io/s9kbp/?view_only=07093b2c81ac4b79b4011877d0cf4c54).

5.1.2 Results and discussion. Manipulation check confirmed that the participants in the high identity-congruence condition perceived the CG as highly congruent with the recipient's identity ($F(1, 103) = 118.70, p < 0.001, M_{\text{high}} = 5.85, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.65; M_{\text{low}} = 4.52, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.58$) than the low identity-congruence condition. An ANOVA with gift preference as a dependent variable showed a main effect of identity congruence ($F(1, 103) = 23.87, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.18$), such that givers indicated a higher preference to give to a charity that closely matched with the recipient ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.66, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.99; M_{\text{low}} = 4.64, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.14$). This result supported **Hypothesis 1a**.

We conducted a mediation analysis (5,000 bootstraps) with recipient's identity-congruence (low = 0, high = 1) as the independent variable, the warm-glow effect as the mediator, and gift preference as the dependent variable (PROCESS MODEL 4; Hayes, 2017, Figure 1) and found a significant indirect effect of identity-congruence on gifting preference through warm-glow ($\beta = 0.79, 95\% \text{ CI} = [0.51, 1.05]$). The participants felt that recipients would receive a higher degree of warm glow while receiving a high (vs. low) identity-congruent CG ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.79, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.98; M_{\text{low}} = 4.43, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.87$). This result supported **Hypothesis 1b**.

5.2 Study 1B

Study 1B was a replication of Study 1A in a different context designed to reconfirm the findings of Study 1A. We employed a single factor between-subjects design by manipulating the level of identity-congruence of the CG.



Note(s): (1) The value of 0.22 is the direct effect of Recipient's Identity-congruent on Gifting Preference while controlling for the mediator. (2) The value of 1.01 is the total effect of Recipient's Identity-congruent on Gifting Preference. (3) Path coefficients represent unstandardized regression weights *** $p \leq .001$

Source(s): Authors' own creation

Figure 1. Mediation analysis model

5.2.1 Method. Initially, 119 students at a large Southeast Asian university participated in the study, which resulted in 104 eligible responses (46% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 23.75$ years), as 15 participants failed the attention check.

The participants read a scenario similar to Study 1 A. The only difference was that in the high identity-congruence condition, they encountered another charity (Option B-Dog welfare), and in the low identity-congruence condition, they encountered another charity (Option B-Tiger welfare). Similar to Study 1A, participants rated their relative gift preference, the manipulation check, and the warm-glow effect.

5.2.2 Results and discussion. Manipulation check confirmed that the participants in the high identity-congruence condition perceived the CG as highly congruent with the recipient's identity ($F(1, 102) = 63.80, p < 0.001, M_{\text{high}} = 5.66, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.68; M_{\text{low}} = 4.30, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.00$) than the low identity-congruence condition. An ANOVA with gift preference as a dependent variable showed a main effect of identity congruence ($F(1, 102) = 23.08, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.18$) such that those in high identity-congruence condition were significantly more likely to deviate from the gift registry and donate to a charity that closely matches the recipient's identity ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.51, SD_{\text{high}} = 1.02; M_{\text{low}} = 4.41, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.27$).

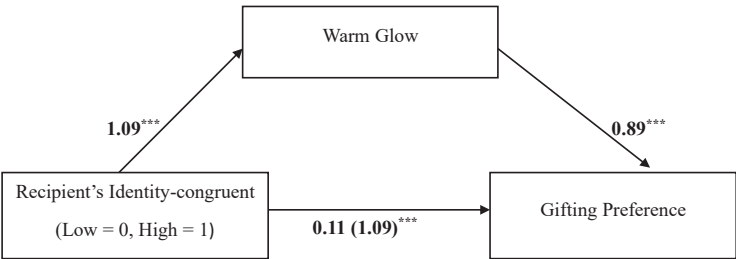
We performed a mediation analysis (5,000 bootstraps) with the recipient's identity-congruence (low = 0, high = 1) as the independent variable, warm-glow effect as the mediator, and gift preference as the dependent variable (PROCESS MODEL 4; Hayes, 2017; See Figure 2). The results indicated a significant indirect effect of identity congruence on gifting preference through warm glow ($\beta = 0.97, 95\% \text{ CI} = [0.63, 1.34]$). The participants felt that receivers experienced a higher warm-glow for a high (vs. low) identity-congruent CG ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.39, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.90; M_{\text{low}} = 4.30, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.03$). Taken together, this study complemented Study 1A.

6. Study 2

Study 2 intended to test Hypothesis 2 by having participants assume the role of either a close or distant giver. We employed a 2 (Social closeness: close friend vs. acquaintance) by 2 (Identity-congruence: low vs. high) between-subjects design.

6.1 Method

Initially, 247 participants from the same university as in Study 1 participated in this preregistered (https://aspredicted.org/K5X_ZHH) study.



Note(s): (1) The value of 0.11 is the direct effect of Recipient's Identity-congruent on Gifting Preference while controlling for the mediator. (2) The value of 1.09 is the total effect of Recipient's Identity-congruent on Gifting Preference. (3) Path coefficients represent unstandardized regression weights *** $p \leq .001$

Source(s): Authors' own creation

Figure 2. Mediation analysis model

The participants read about their close friend (acquaintance), a nature lover who always advocates for tree conservation and environmental protection. They read that they were invited to their friend's (acquaintance) birthday party, who requested them to donate to a specific charity (Option A- Gift registry- Charity to save the earth). The participants in the high identity-congruence condition read that while browsing online for the same charity, they encountered another charity (Option B- Charity to save and plant trees). In the low identity-congruence condition, the participants imagined the same scenario. The only difference was that they encountered another charity (Option B- Charity to save oceans). The participants rated their relative preference between the two gifts on a 7-point scale (1 = Option A, 7 = Option B). The respondents completed a comprehension check for social closeness manipulation ("During this exercise, did you imagine the recipient as a?", a. Close friend, b. Acquaintance/colleague), identity-congruence manipulation check, and the attention check.

6.2 Results and discussion

Nine participants failed the comprehension check for social closeness, and twenty-five failed the attention check. We excluded those participants who failed any of these checks (Han and Newman, 2022), leaving a total of 213 participants (42% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 23.51$ years) for analysis. However, including these respondents does not significantly alter our findings.

Manipulation checks confirmed that the participants in the high identity-congruence condition perceived the charitable gift as highly congruent with the recipient's identity ($F(1, 211) = 51.43, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.19, M_{\text{high}} = 5.64, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.67; M_{\text{low}} = 4.91, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.79$) than the low identity-congruence condition.

We performed a two-way ANOVA on gift preference with the identity-congruence gift and social closeness as independent variables. There was a main effect of identity $F(1, 209) = 109.53, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.34$ such that participants were more likely to choose high identity-congruent gift as ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.50, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.13$, vs. $M_{\text{low}} = 3.92, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.12$) compared to low identity-congruent gift. However, there was no significant difference in the gift preference between socially close and distant groups ($F(1, 209) = 0.002, p = 0.962, \eta^2 < 0.001$). Furthermore, there was a significant identity $\times$ social closeness interaction effect ($F(1, 209) = 17.98, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.07$). Specifically, in the socially close condition, the preference for a high-identity congruent gift was significantly higher as compared to the low-identity-congruent option ($F(1, 209) = 110.71, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.34, M_{\text{high}} = 5.80, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.98$, vs. $M_{\text{low}} = 3.60, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.08$). Additionally, in the distant condition, the preference for the high-identity congruent gift was also significantly higher than the low-identity congruent alternative $F(1, 209) = 18.93, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.08, M_{\text{high}} = 5.18, SD_{\text{high}} = 1.21$ vs. $M_{\text{low}} = 4.25, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.09$), albeit its effect was weaker than the previous case. (See Figure 3).

The findings of Study 2 lend support to Hypothesis 2. The closer the relationship between the giver and the recipient, the more likely the giver will try to match the gift with the recipient's identity.

7. Study 3

Study 3 intended to test Hypothesis 3. Gifts signal relationship closeness, and givers are motivated to please the recipient. However, when givers do not receive the attribution (the giver's name is unknown) for the gift, then gift-givers are less likely to choose an identity-congruent charitable gift. Anonymity (the giver's name is unknown) demotivates gift-givers to choose an identity-congruent gift because anonymity removes the relationship signal. When givers receive attribution (the giver's name is disclosed) for the gift, they are encouraged to choose an identity-congruent gift, which signals relationship closeness. We expect participants in non-anonymous conditions (the giver's name is known) to deviate from the charitable gift registry if they encounter an option that is highly congruous with the recipient's identity. We

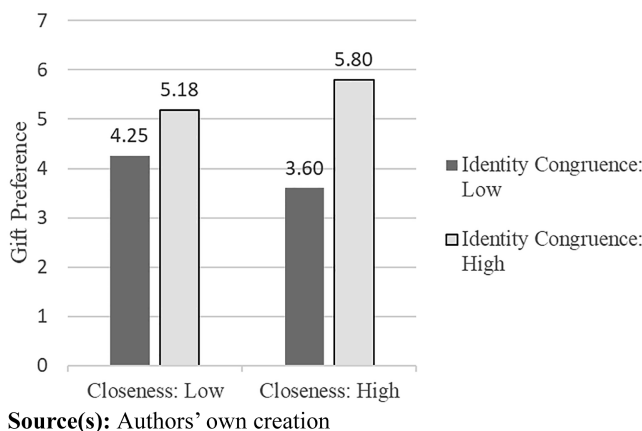


Figure 3. Interaction effect of closeness and identity congruence on gift preference

employed a 2 (Attribution: non-anonymous vs. anonymous) by 2 (Identity-congruence: low vs. high) between-subjects design.

7.1 Method

Initially, 236 students participated in this preregistered (https://aspredicted.org/9SH_H5Y) study. Participants read the same scenario as in Study 1B, in which a colleague is a dog lover, and they were invited to the party. The only difference was that the participants in the anonymous condition read that the charitable organization would not disclose their identity to the recipient about the donation made by them on the recipient’s behalf. In the control condition, the gifting context was similar, with no mention of the gift being anonymous. Participants rated their relative preference between the two gifts; a comprehension check for gift anonymity (“During this exercise, did you imagine that your colleague was supposed to know who has given the gift during the party?”, a. No, b. Yes), identity-congruence manipulation check, and the attention check.

7.2 Results and discussion

Eighteen participants did not complete the questionnaire. Five participants failed the comprehension check for the role of anonymity, and fifteen failed the attention check. We excluded those participants who failed any of these checks, leaving a total of 198 participants (38% female, $M_{age} = 23.90$ years) for analysis. However, including these respondents does not significantly alter our findings.

Manipulation checks confirmed that the participants in the high identity-congruence condition perceived the charitable gift as highly congruent with the recipient’s identity ($F(1, 196) = 101.88, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.34, M_{high} = 5.75, SD_{high} = 0.75; M_{low} = 4.44, SD_{low} = 1.06$) than the low identity-congruence condition.

We performed a two-way ANOVA on gift preference with identity and anonymity as independent variables. As per our formulation, participants’ preference for the identity-congruent gift was significantly higher ($F(1, 194) = 3.79, p = 0.053, \eta^2 = 0.02$) when the identity-congruent option was present. Additionally, the preference for identity-congruent gifts was significantly higher ($F(1, 194) = 17.79, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.08$) under non-anonymous conditions. Furthermore, there was a significant identity-congruence and anonymity interaction effect ($F(1, 194) = 10.98, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.05$). Specifically, in the non-anonymous condition, the preference for a high-identity congruent gift was significantly

higher as compared to the low-identity congruent option ($F(1, 194) = 14.87, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.07, M_{\text{high}} = 5.78, SD_{\text{high}} = 1.03$, vs. $M_{\text{low}} = 4.88, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.25$). However, in the anonymous condition, there was no significant difference between the two groups $F(1, 194) = 0.87, p = 0.351, \eta^2 = 0.004, M_{\text{high}} = 4.49, SD_{\text{high}} = 1.35$ vs. $M_{\text{low}} = 4.73, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.10$) (See Figure 4).

These findings support Hypothesis 3. When givers get attribution for the gift, they deviate from the gift registry and donate to a charity that closely resembles the recipient's identity. This behavior is supposed to signal closeness to the relationship. However, gift givers do not deviate from the gift registry when they do not receive attribution for the gift, as there is no scope for signaling relationship closeness.

8. Study 4

This study intended to test Hypothesis 4 by asking the participants to assume the role of a receiver. We employed a 2 (Social closeness: close friend vs. acquaintance) by 2 (Identity-congruence: low vs. high) between-subjects design.

8.1 Method

Initially, 229 students participated in this preregistered (https://aspredicted.org/X8T_3QY) study. The participants read that they are passionate about guitar and give free guitar lessons to school children. They read that they organized their birthday party and invited their friends, and instead of receiving gifts for themselves, they requested givers to donate to a specific charity. At last, they read that while opening the gift, they received a different CG from their friend or acquaintance. Participants were asked how receiving this gift changed their relationship with the giver (1 = felt more disconnected, 7 = felt more connected; Chan and Mogilner, 2016). After indicating the relationship strength, respondents completed a comprehension check manipulation for social closeness ("During this exercise, did you imagine the giver as a?", a. Close friend, b. Acquaintance/colleague). They also completed a manipulation check for identity congruence (e.g. "The gift reflects your interests." 1 = not at all, 7 = very much). Participants also indicated the warm glow effect using four items on a 7-point scale adapted from Hartmann et al., (2017) (e.g. "With the receipt of this gift, you will have a pleasant feeling of personal satisfaction by doing something about the cause,"; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.86$). Finally, they responded to the attention check.

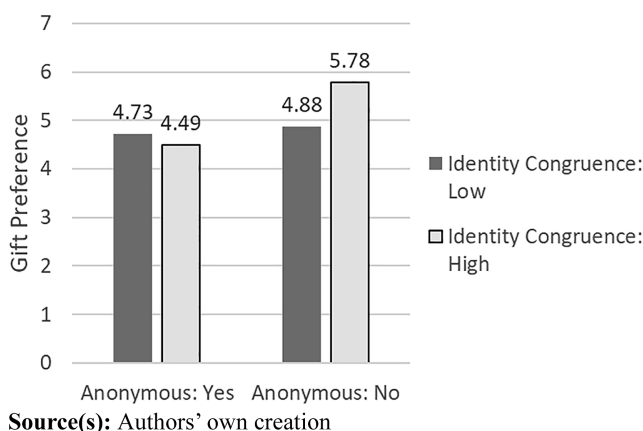


Figure 4. Interaction effect of anonymity and identity congruence on gift preference

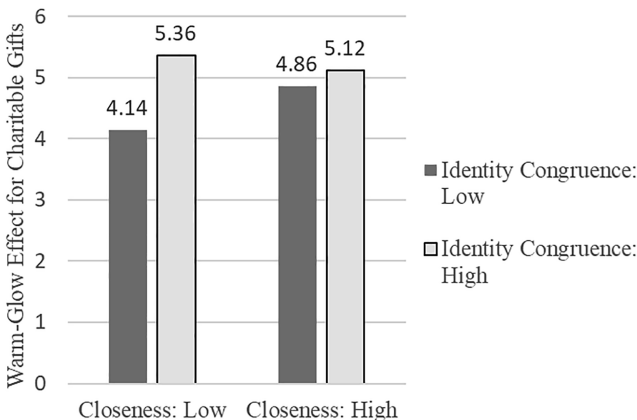
8.2 Results and discussion

Six participants failed the comprehension check for social closeness, and eight failed the attention check. We excluded those participants who failed any of these checks, leaving a total of 215 participants (47% female, $M_{\text{age}} = 23.63$ years) for analysis. However, including these respondents does not significantly alter our findings.

Manipulation checks confirmed that the participants in the high identity-congruence condition perceived the charitable gift as highly congruent with the recipient's identity ($F(1, 213) = 344.71, p < 0.001, M_{\text{high}} = 5.88, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.63; M_{\text{low}} = 3.81, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.97$) than the low identity-congruence condition.

A 2 (Social: close vs. acquaintance) by 2 (Identity-congruence: low vs. high) between-subjects design ANOVA with warm-glow effect as a dependent variable showed the main effect of identity-congruence ($F(1, 211) = 35.37, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.14$) such that participants received a higher warm glow in receiving high identity congruent gift ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.24, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.80; M_{\text{low}} = 4.50, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.08$). There also exists the interaction effect of social closeness and identity congruence ($F(1, 211) = 14.80, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.06$). Specifically, recipients were more likely to receive a higher warm-glow effect from distant givers by receiving identity congruent gift compared to the low-identity congruent option ($F(1, 211) = 47.36, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.18, M_{\text{high}} = 5.36, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.72, \text{vs. } M_{\text{low}} = 4.14, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.12$). However, in the socially close condition, there was no significant difference between the two groups ($F(1, 211) = 2.23, p = 0.137, \eta^2 = 0.01, M_{\text{high}} = 5.12, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.85 \text{ vs. } M_{\text{low}} = 4.86, SD_{\text{low}} = 0.93$) (See Figure 5).

A 2 (Social: close vs. acquaintance) by 2 (Identity-congruence: low vs. high) between-subjects design ANOVA with change in the relationship as the dependent variable indicated the main effect of identity ($F(1, 211) = 40.69, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.16$) such that participants preferred high identity-congruence compared to low congruence ($M_{\text{high}} = 5.32, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.88; M_{\text{low}} = 4.46, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.14$). We also observed the interaction effect of social closeness and identity-congruence ($F(1, 211) = 13.19, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.05$). Specifically, in socially distant condition, the relationship improves significantly higher in the high identity-congruence option than low identity-congruence option ($F(1, 211) = 49.47, p < 0.001, \eta^2 = 0.19, M_{\text{high}} = 5.53, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.89; M_{\text{low}} = 4.17, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.15$). However, social closeness had an insignificant effect ($F(1, 211) = 3.82, p = 0.052, \eta^2 = 0.02, M_{\text{high}} = 5.12, SD_{\text{high}} = 0.84; M_{\text{low}} = 4.75, SD_{\text{low}} = 1.06$) (See Figure 6).



Source(s): Authors' own creation

Figure 5. Interaction effect of closeness and identity congruence on warm-glow effect

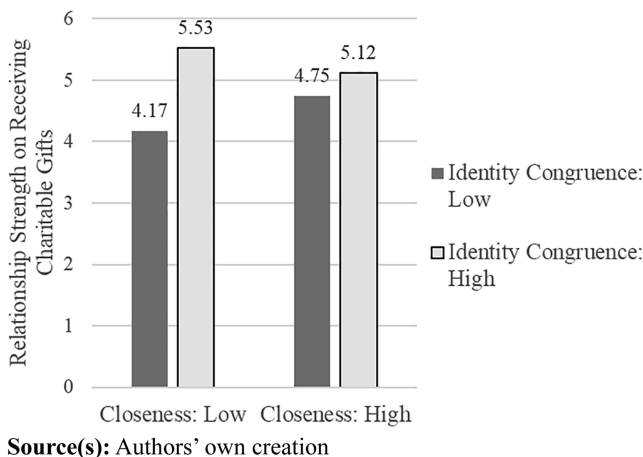
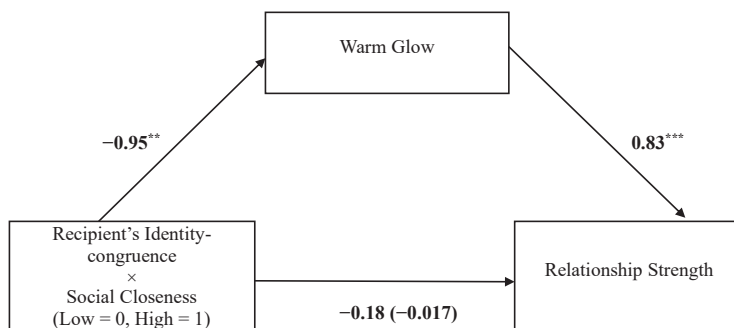


Figure 6. Interaction effect of closeness and identity congruence on relationship strength

We also performed moderated mediation analysis (5,000 bootstraps) by including the recipient's identity-congruence (low = 0, high = 1) as the independent variable, the giver's social closeness as a moderator (acquaintance = 0, close = 1), warm-glow effect as a mediator, and relationship strength as a dependent variable (PROCESS MODEL 8; Hayes, 2017; See Figure 7). The results indicated that in the acquaintance condition, identity congruence had a significant indirect effect on relationship strength through the warm-glow effect (effect = 1.01, SE = 0.16, 95% CI = [0.70, 1.35]). However, in the close friend condition, the indirect effect was not significant (effect = 0.21, SE = 0.14, 95% CI = [-0.06,



Note(s): (1) Coding for recipient's identity-congruence: Low = 0 versus High = 1. Coding for social closeness: Acquaintance = 0 versus Close = 1. (2) The value of -0.95 is the regression coefficient for the interaction effect of recipient's identity-congruence × social closeness on the warm glow. (3) The value of -0.18 is the regression coefficient for the interaction effect of recipient's identity-congruence × social closeness on the relationship strength. (4) The value in paranthesis is the regression coefficient of recipient's identity-congruence × social closeness on the relationship strength after controlling for the mediator. (5) Significance level: ** $p \leq 0.05$, *** $p \leq 0.001$

Source(s): Authors' own creation

Figure 7. Moderated mediation model

0.49]). Furthermore, the index of moderated mediation was significant (index = -0.79 , SE = 0.21 , 95% CI = $[-1.24, -0.38]$).

Thus, the results support [hypothesis 4](#). The relationship between the giver and the recipient improves when the recipient receives an identity-congruous gift. Our findings also indicate that a warm glow mediates the effect of social closeness on the change in relationship strength only when the distant giver gives the high identity congruent gift but not when the close giver gives the gift.

9. General discussion

Studies 1–3 demonstrated that gift-givers deviate from the registry if they encounter an option that is highly congruous with the recipient's identity. Study 1A and Study 1B found that this is due to the gift-givers' desire to gift the recipient with a warm-glow. Study 2 demonstrated that socially close givers tend to deviate from the gift registry to signal their relationship closeness. These results are similar to those of [Ward and Broniarczyk \(2016\)](#), demonstrating how close givers deviate from the registry to exhibit their social closeness with the recipient. Study 3 examined the role of anonymity, which impacts the preference for identity-congruent gifts, such that when givers are anonymous, they are less likely to deviate from the gift registry, highlighting the importance of attribution in gifting. Finally, Study 4 demonstrated that recipients experience a warm-glow effect on receiving unrequested identity-congruous CGs. This effect is magnified in the case of distant givers, which strengthen social ties. These findings contrast earlier research ([Paolacci et al., 2015](#); [Ward and Broniarczyk, 2016](#)) on gifting asymmetries and their adverse effects on social proximity by demonstrating that gifting deviation does not always hamper giver-recipient relationships.

10. Contributions

10.1 Theoretical

Our work contributes to the existing gifting literature, warm-glow theory, and inter-relationship dynamics. Firstly, we explore a new gift type—a CG. Prior research has focused on tangible gifts that directly benefit recipients ([Chan and Mogilner, 2016](#); [Paolacci et al., 2015](#)) and making charitable choices for the self ([Bekkers and Wiepking, 2011](#)). We explore situations that involve charitable donations for others. [Sherry's \(1983\)](#) seminal work indicated altruism and agonism as two primary motives of gift-giving. Our work demonstrates that gift-givers deviate from the gift registry to give the recipient a warm glow to strengthen relationships. This indicates that charitable gift-givers are partially motivated by agonistic motives.

Secondly, we focus on factors that influence givers' decision-making in selecting a CG. Prior studies have primarily focused on the receiver's appreciation and misappreciation of such gifts ([Cavanaugh et al., 2015](#); [Ok et al., 2020](#)). Our research contributes to the existing literature by illustrating the influence of a recipient's identity on a giver's decision-making process. Previous research on gift-giving has yielded contradictory results regarding the significance of identity. [Paolacci et al., \(2015\)](#) contend that recipients favor gifts that correspond to the identity of the givers, while [Gino and Flynn \(2011\)](#) demonstrate that recipients favor gifts that correspond to their own identities. Our work attempts to resolve this conflict by demonstrating that not only do recipients prefer CGs that match their own identity but also that givers are aware of it.

Thirdly, our study offers significant advances to the warm-glow theory. [Hartmann et al., \(2017\)](#) empirically investigated the warm glow effect in the context of pro-environmental behavior and found it to be a powerful mechanism that encourages sustained participation in prosocial action by reinforcing positive emotions. Experiencing positive feelings like a warm glow can induce learning effects that influence future behavior toward altruism, kindness, and generosity. Our research, for the first time, demonstrates the significance of the warm-glow

effect in the context of gift-giving. The results indicate that givers deviate towards charitable gifts that are congruent with the recipient's identity in order to gift them a feeling of warm-glow.

Lastly, we develop a better understanding of how charitable gifts affect interpersonal relationships. We show that givers deviate from the registry to gift a warm glow to enhance cohesion in interpersonal relationships. This is indeed the case as recipients, too, feel closer to the givers when they deviate from the gift registry toward gifts that match the recipient's identity. Moreover, this effect is enhanced for distant givers, as recipients probably have fewer expectations from them. This signals the giver's thoughtfulness, enhancing the emotional connection between the giver and recipient, which may develop enduring and meaningful relationships.

10.2 Managerial and societal implications

This research provides substantial implications for policymakers and charitable organizations by identifying an executable strategy for promoting CGs. Charitable organizations use message-framing techniques to solicit donations, but the optimal application of these techniques remains largely obscure. Our research can potentially assist them in developing impactful strategies, thereby stimulating donations.

First, our study consistently demonstrates that identity plays a significant role in charity selection, which can benefit charitable organizations. Fundraisers can determine which identities a specific charity should highlight in its campaigns to increase donations. For example, in the gifting context, givers are consistently motivated to prefer the recipient's identity-congruous gifts to elicit appreciation and strengthen interpersonal relationships. When charitable donations are requested in a gift registry, organizations must strategically evoke the recipient's identity with the gift registry. Marketers can frame identity-based appeals to resonate with the donor's identity and increase responsible consumption behavior (Kumar and Dholakia, 2022).

Second, this research suggests that an emotional construct such as a warm-glow effect can further assist fundraisers in employing emotional appeals in their marketing campaigns. Since CGs lack tangibility, the warm-glow effect can add a certain degree of tangibility. Marketers can encourage consumers to choose CGs by communicating the warm-glow benefits by creating narratives like, "Your gift cultivates hope. Experience the pleasure of contributing to society." to evoke empathy and highlight the social impact of CGs. Marketers can also share stories from other gift receivers about how CGs make a tangible difference in the initiative. Marketers can also express gratitude to the gift recipients for CGs and emphasize that their efforts are recognized, which can promote feelings of fulfillment. Receivers receiving a warm glow will establish an emotional connection with the cause and might continue supporting the organization.

Third, charitable organizations can benefit by framing charitable giving as a gift (Wang et al., 2023). Donations as CGs have the potential to enhance the prosocial behavior of the givers and augment their overall contribution. Such donations can communicate the symbolic meaning of social closeness between the giver and the receiver. This research suggests that receiving an unrequested identity-congruous charitable gift from close givers does not hamper the relationship. However, receiving unrequested charitable gifts from distant givers that align with the recipient's identity can be overpowering.

Our research also offers societal implications. CGs foster a sense of generosity and empathy, assisting organizations in leveraging the network of their fundraisers, who encourage their family and friends to donate to the cause. Therefore, CGs can become a vital component of their financial ecosystem. We show that identity-congruent CGs satisfy recipients, which may enhance their propensity to seek more donations on other occasions. Second, CGs cultivate responsible behavior. Individuals can be motivated for prosocial behavior by augmenting their knowledge of the warm-glow effect (Hartmann et al., 2017). Observing the

generosity of others can inspire people to engage in comparable acts of altruism and charitable gifting. Ultimately, charitable gifts create a ripple effect that extends far beyond the initial act of gifting.

11. Limitations and future research directions

Firstly, we studied the impact of the recipient's identity in decision-making while overlooking the giver's identity. Ward and Broniarczyk (2011) indicated that givers feel an identity threat while giving identity-contrary gifts. In this research, we did not check if givers experience an identity threat if they encounter an identity-incongruent CG that is highly congruent with the recipient's identity. Therefore, researchers can investigate the interaction between the giver's identity and the type of charity when it is incongruent with the former.

Secondly, in this research, the gift-receiver sacrifices a tangible gift for a CG. Since CGs offer a glimpse into an individual's moral identity, it may be fascinating to investigate the factors that motivate an individual to request them. Some people may genuinely empathize with the beneficiaries of these gifts and wish to assist them. In contrast, others may do so to project their self-image. Scholars (Chapman *et al.*, 2020) have shown how status motives make people sensitive toward prosocial behavior. Examining whether the costly signaling theory significantly influences recipients' inclination to request CGs may be beneficial.

Lastly, we show that receivers are not offended when givers deviate from the registry. However, we did this by providing the respondents with gift registries that only included CG contributions. CGs, whether congruent or incongruent, can be explored to evaluate whether they produce offense when receivers indicate a desire for a tangible gift rather than a CG.

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